POLICY BRIEF

Ireland’s Maritime Surveillance Gap

What Ireland can see at sea, what it cannot, and what is changing

Security Ireland

2026

IN BRIEF

Ireland’s maritime area is approximately 880,000 km², roughly ten times its land area. The standing assets watching it include: eight naval vessels of which typically around four are in the operational rotation, two C295W maritime patrol aircraft, and a Naval Service at 807 personnel against an establishment of 1,094.

The threat to this maritime area not hypothetical. In November 2024 the Russian vessel Yantar switched off its transponder inside the Irish EEZ and loitered near subsea cables and a gas interconnector before LÉ James Joyce escorted it out; it returned toward Irish waters in November 2025. In December 2025, drones circled LÉ William Butler Yeats during the Zelenskyy visit.

Change is underway — sonar and subsea awareness funded in Budget 2026, radar by 2028, CISE membership, a PESCO seabed-protection project, a UK subsea framework — but every programme matures between 2026 and 2028. The surveillance gap is closing on a timeline; it is not closed.

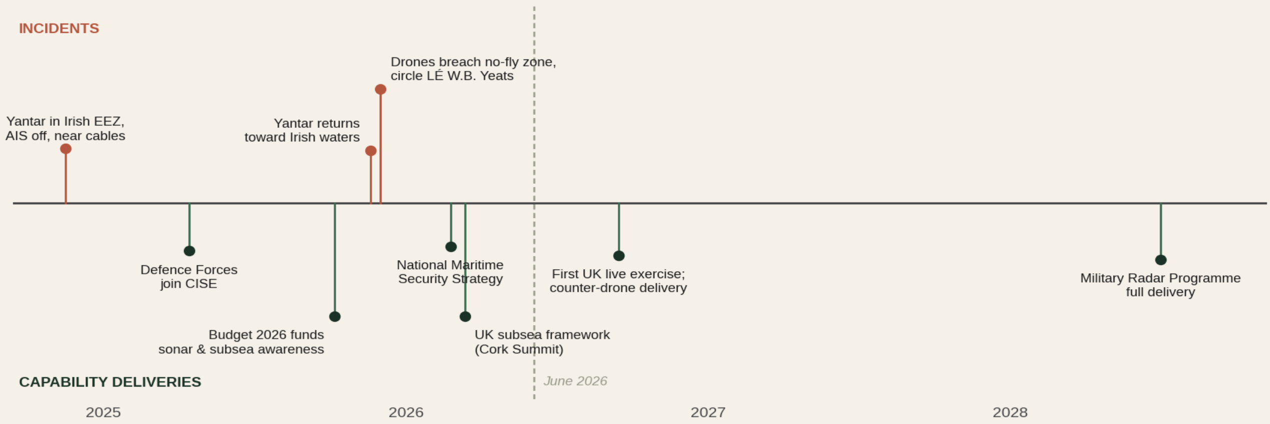

Figure 1 — Incidents and capability deliveries, 2024–2028. Sources: Irish Times, Irish Examiner (Nov 2024; Nov 2025); The Journal, RTÉ (Dec 2025); gov.ie (Apr 2025; Oct 2025; Feb 2026); UK Government (Mar 2026); Oireachtas (Feb 2026).

1. The domain

Ireland is responsible for a maritime area of approximately 880,000 km², roughly ten times its land area and one of the largest in Europe. What runs through that water makes it strategically significant beyond its size: the subsea data cables connecting Ireland to Britain, Europe and North America, and the energy links on which the State depends. Around 80% of Ireland’s gas arrives through a single interconnection point at Moffat in Scotland, with the Corrib field, supplying roughly 20%, in decline toward full import dependency by the early 2030s (Gas Networks Ireland).

2. What Ireland can currently see

Surface: the Naval Service operates eight vessels — four Samuel Beckett-class offshore patrol vessels (commissioned 2014–2019), two Róisín-class held in reserve, and two Lake-class inshore patrol vessels acquired from New Zealand in 2023, of which LÉ Aoibhinn is operational and LÉ Gobnait is not yet operational. Typically around four vessels are in the operational rotation (three P60s plus LÉ Aoibhinn as of November 2025); in March 2025, four of eight were available for operations. The service stood at 807 personnel at end-2025 against an establishment of 1,094 — though with a net gain of 115 in 2025, the strongest recovery of the three services.

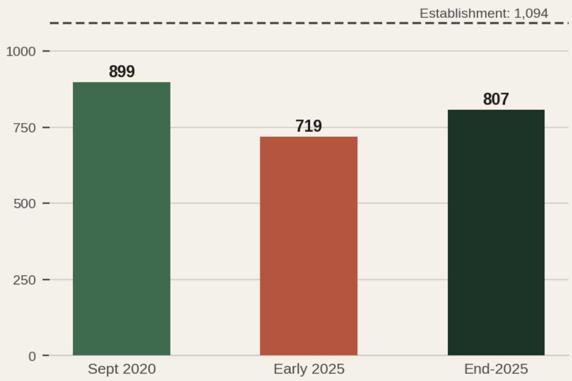

Figure 2 — Naval Service strength against establishment of 1,094. Sources: Dáil record (Nov 2020; Feb 2025); Dept of Defence end-2025 return.

Air: two Airbus C295W maritime patrol aircraft, delivered in 2023, provide the airborne surveillance capability. They are the aircraft that shadowed the Yantar in November 2024.

Sensors and data: the Naval Service Operations Centre monitors activity in Ireland's area of interest and can exchange information with other European navies through the European Defence Agency's MARSUR network (Department of Defence). Until the current procurement programmes deliver, however, Ireland has no primary radar coverage of its airspace and approaches, and no standing subsea sensing capability: the picture below the surface is, for now, largely supplied by partners or not available at all.

3. The pattern of incidents

November 2024. The Russian vessel Yantar — officially an oceanographic research ship, assessed by Western military intelligence as equipped for surveillance and possible sabotage of marine infrastructure, entered the Irish EEZ, switched off its automatic identification system, and operated near subsea communications cables and a gas interconnector pipeline. LÉ James Joyce shadowed it overnight and escorted it out of the EEZ at around 3am; an Air Corps maritime patrol aircraft was dispatched. At one stage Irish military personnel observed three drones in the air which appeared to be under the control of the ship.

November 2025. The Yantar returned toward Irish waters on a similar route. The UK Defence Secretary said it had pointed lasers at RAF pilots monitoring it, and changed the Royal Navy's rules of engagement to shadow it more closely.

December 2025. During President Zelenskyy's visit to Dublin, four military-style drones breached a no-fly zone toward the flight path of his aircraft and later circled LÉ William Butler Yeats; counter-drone protection around Leinster House was operated by Portuguese and French police units with the PSNI.

The official response confirms the assessment: in April 2025 the Tánaiste ordered officials to accelerate the planned radar and sonar purchases, citing Russian naval activity in Irish-controlled waters (RTÉ).

4. What is changing, and when

National Maritime Security Strategy. Ireland's first, published February 2026, covering 2026–2030 with six strategic objectives.

Sonar and subsea awareness. Towed-array sonar and the Subsea Awareness programme funded in

Budget 2026, within a record €300m capital allocation.

Radar. The Military Radar Programme — Ireland's first primary radar — begins phased rollout in 2026 with full delivery by 2028, and will include maritime ship-borne radar (Minister for Defence, February 2026).

CISE. The Defence Forces joined the EU's Common Information Sharing Environment in April 2025, exchanging maritime surveillance information with military and civilian authorities in ten other European states; the network became fully operational in late 2024.

PESCO. Ireland became a full participant in the Critical Seabed Infrastructure Protection project with Dáil approval in July 2024, alongside its existing maritime surveillance project participation.

UK–Ireland. The Cork Summit of 13 March 2026 produced a refreshed Defence MoU and a Subsea Infrastructure Bilateral Collaboration Framework, with the first joint live exercise scheduled for September 2026.

5. What remains — Security Ireland assessment

Set the verified facts side by side and the gap defines itself. The surveillance burden — one of Europe's largest maritime areas, carrying critical data and energy infrastructure that hostile vessels have demonstrably surveyed — falls today on roughly four available ships, two patrol aircraft, and a naval service at 74% of establishment. Every capability that would change this — sonar, ship-borne radar, the UK framework's live exercises — delivers between 2026 and 2028. Ireland's EU Presidency in the second half of 2026, with subsea infrastructure on the European agenda, therefore arrives in the middle of the transition rather than after it. The question this brief poses is whether their timelines, and the crewing levels needed to operate what they deliver, match the pattern of incidents already on the record.

SOURCES

Maritime area and energy — Government of Ireland; Gas Networks Ireland. Fleet, availability, personnel — Naval Service records (Nov 2025); Dept of Defence end-2025 return; Dáil record. Aircraft — Dept of Defence (2023). Yantar — Irish Times, Irish Examiner (Nov 2024; Nov 2025). Drones — The Journal, RTÉ (Dec 2025). Procurement acceleration — RTÉ (Apr 2025). NMSS, Budget 2026, CISE — gov.ie (2025–26). Radar — Oireachtas (Feb 2026). PESCO — Dáil record, gov.ie (Jul 2024). Cork Summit — UK Govt, RTÉ (Mar 2026).